(+46) 072 373 32 90
vilhelm.agdur@gmail.com

Vilhelm Agdur
PhD in Applied Mathematics

Portfolio: vagdur.github.io
github.com/vagdur
linkedin.com/in/vilhelm-agdur

Doing a PhD will teach you many things. Sometimes, one of those things is that you'd rather be doing something else.

This may be a surprising opening line, but after all, I am applying for a job that is not another PhD. Many of the things I learned in my PhD are applicable outside of mathematical academia — statistics, programming, scientific writing, and softer skills like teaching and explaining your research — but in a way, the most useful might be that insight about doing something else.

What I mean by this is the discovery of what motivates you and what you want to achieve with your work. Technical skills are excellent for taking you where you want to go, but without knowing where that is, they are rather impotent. For me, that motivation can be summarised in two parts: Doing some tangible good, and doing it in a larger context.

In the first, the word tangible is important — my papers are all fairly applied, so it is entirely reasonable to think they are doing some good. However, they are improvements to our theoretical understanding of a step in the analysis of graph data. The connection between this improvement and an improvement in the life of a real person is real, but very distant.

In the second, I am not saying that mathematics is a solo sport, because it definitely is not — two out of three papers in my thesis are collaborative efforts. Rather, it is that each paper is its own small project, with only a weak connection to any larger goals or contexts. I find that I would rather be part of a team working towards some larger goal, with projects that make sense in that context, rather than being their own self-contained little thing.

Sincerely,



Vilhelm Agdur